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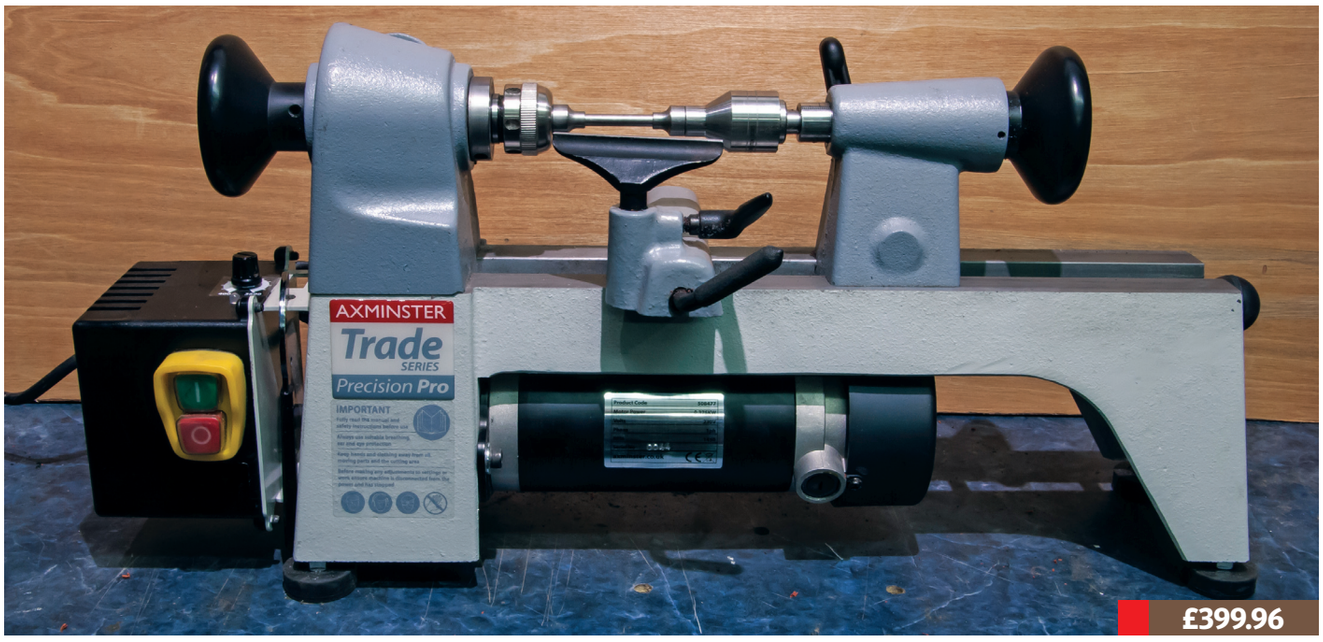
Axminster Trade Series Precision Pro Lathe Test



£399.96

TESTED BY WALTER HALL

Walter Hall is a woodturner who has specialised in making pens and pencils for more than 20 years. Based on the beautiful Northumberland coast in the UK, Walter sells his bespoke pens and pencils through local craft centres and via his website.

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As a pen maker and demonstrator of pen making I have often wished that I could find a small lathe that was easily portable but did not compromise on quality. Most often I found that small lathes were cheaply produced to appeal to the hobby turner while good quality lathes built to finer tolerances tended to be larger, heavier and only semi-portable at best. The Axminster Trade Series Precision Pro Lathe aims to fill this gap in the market and in this review I have put it through its paces to see how well it achieves this aim.

My own requirements for a mini lathe are as follows:

- It must be light enough in weight to be carried easily by one person but robust enough to stand up to daily use in a professional workshop and to the rigours of being transported
- The spindle must be fitted with quality bearings and have minimal run-out or vibration and the tailstock must be free from excessive play in the quill or against the lathe bed. Head and tailstock should align perfectly in both vertical and horizontal planes
- The motor should be quiet but sufficiently powerful for the type of work for which the lathe is designed. It should be rated for continuous running and should have electronic variable speed control
- The lathe must be sufficiently versatile to enable it to be used for other small spindle or faceplate work. A lathe that is useful only for pens is of limited utility

So how well does the Precision Pro meet these requirements and what other features does it have that might widen its appeal beyond pen makers? To begin with, this is not a cheap lathe. At about £400 without any optional extras it is more than twice the price of the similarly-sized entry level AWSL hobby lathe. So what does it offer to justify this price differential?

Weighing in at 22kg, the Precision Pro is easy to transport single-handed and at 699 x 315 x 270mm, is small enough to be stored out of the way when not in use. Light weight does not, however, reflect poor build quality. Being built almost entirely of cast iron and machined to fine tolerances, this is a robust lathe designed for professional use.

The headstock is fitted with oversize ball bearings that result in a smooth running

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